lash Gehlot, defected to the BJP. Meanwhile, the Centre thwarted a Supreme Court judgment that restored control of the bureaucracy to the chief minister by issuing a new ordinance in May 2023 that made the lieutenant governor all-powerful. Though Atishi Marlena, the Oxford-educated activist and cabinet member, became chief minister after Kejriwal resigned in September 2024, the onslaught against its leaders took a toll on governance, which may now cost AAP dear.

THE UNDERPRIVILEGED BASTION OF AAP

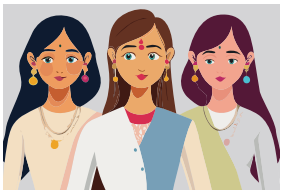
Delhi's electoral history reveals a pattern of stark shifts, with voters overwhelmingly favouring AAP in assembly elections and decisively backing the BJP in the Lok Sabha polls. Around 30 per cent of Delhi's voters alternate their support depending on which type of election it is. This includes 15 per cent swing voters for the BJP in the Lok Sabha election and 30 per cent for AAP in the state polls. Psephologists describe the upcoming assembly election as a bipolar contest between AAP and the BJP, with AAP retaining the edge at

Psephologists describe the upcoming assembly election as a bipolar contest between AAP and the BJP, with the Congress likely to play spoiler

the start of the campaign. Sanjay Kumar, co-director, Lokniti programme, at the Centre for the Study of Developing Societies (CSDS), says, "The 2025 Delhi election will be vastly different from the 2020 one in which AAP had won votes from all sections of society in different proportions. The euphoria for Kejriwal and his leadership among all classes was evident. But in 2025, the middle class is now seen as being disenchanted with Kejriwal. So, to win, he must retain his hold over the lower middle class and poor sections of society apart from the minorities." Yashwant Deshmukh, founder-director of C-Voter, agrees. "Kejriwal's image as an anti-corruption crusader has gone for a toss. In our tracker, his popularity ratings have dropped from the stratospheric heights of 60 per cent as compared to his nearest CM rival to around 48 per cent—a 12 percentage point drop," he says, only to add, "but these are still high

POLLPOURRI FOR DELHIITES

What AAP, BJP and Congress each have promised in a bid to woo different sections of the electorate—women, youth, elderly—in their respective manifestos

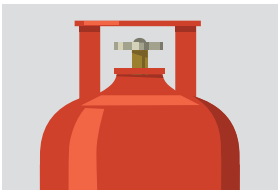


WOMEN

AAP: Rs 2,100 a month allowance under Mahila Samman Yojana

BJP: Rs 2,500 monthly payout under Mahila Samriddhi Yojana

Congress: Rs 2,500 per month under Pyari Didi Yojana



COOKING GAS

AAP: Rs 500 subsidy per cylinder

BJP: Subsidised cylinders at Rs 500, free cylinders on Holi and Diwali

Congress: Subsidised cylinders for Rs 500

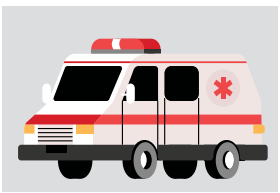


YOUTH

AAP: Employment focus, free bus rides and metro concessions for students, scholarships under Dr Ambedkar Yojana

BJP: 50,000 government jobs, 2 million self-employment opportunities, Rs 15,000 aid for competitive exams

Congress: Rs 8,500/year under Yuva Udaan Yojana + apprenticeships



HEALTHCARE

AAP: Free treatment for senior citizens, continuation of Mohalla Clinics. Sanjeevani Yojana provides free treatment in addition

BJP: Rs 5 lakh Ayushman Bharat cover + Rs 5 lakh state cover, free diagnostics for all

Congress: Health insurance coverage up to Rs 25 lakh under Jeevan Raksha Yojana